



◁ **NGC 5897**
Unlike other globular clusters, NGC 5897 does not have a dense nucleus where stars are increasingly squashed together. It brightens only gradually toward its center.

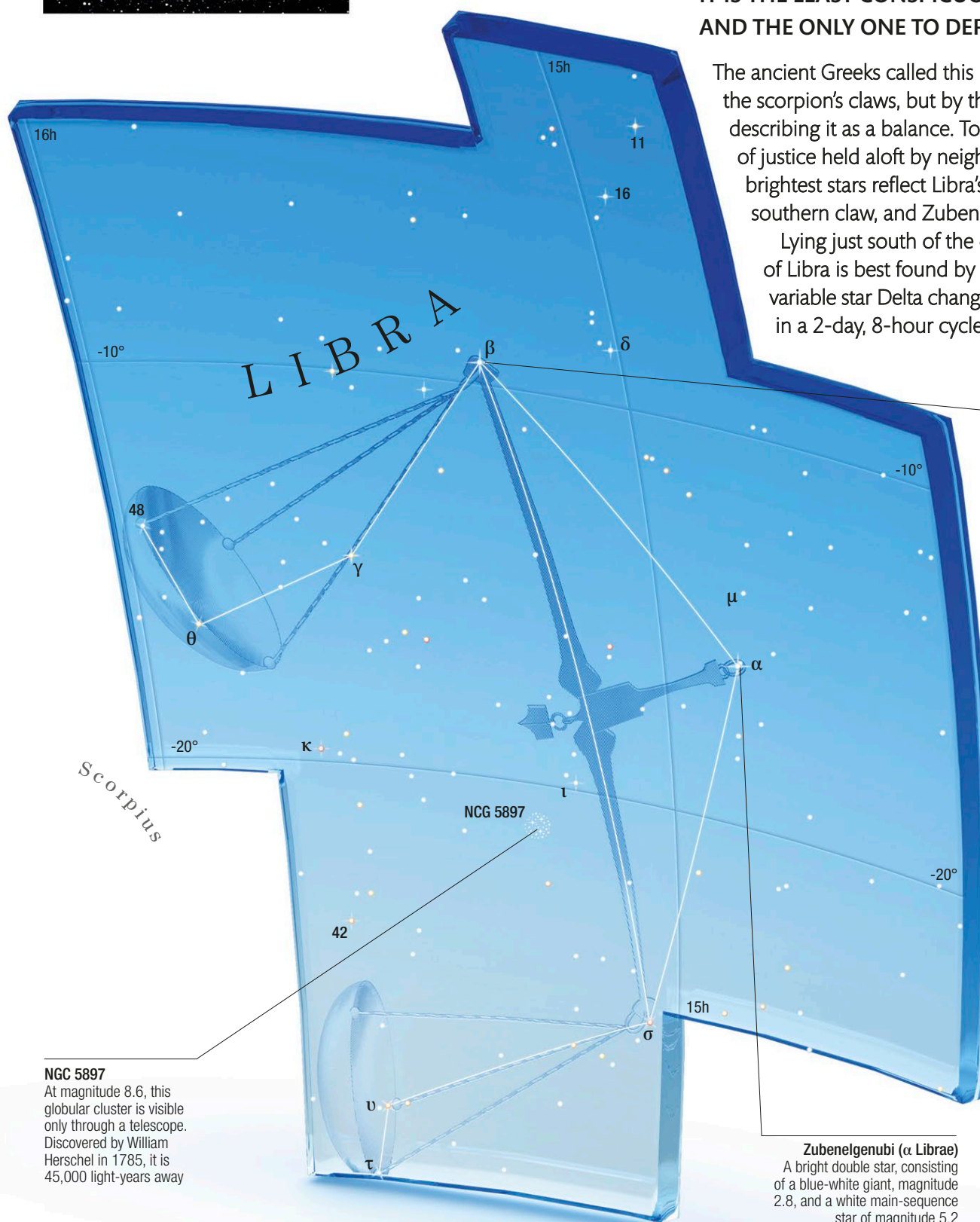
LIBRA

THE SCALES

OCCUPYING AN AREA OF SKY ONCE SEEN AS PART OF SCORPIUS, LIBRA REPRESENTS THE SCALES OF JUSTICE. IT IS THE LEAST CONSPICUOUS ZODIAC CONSTELLATION AND THE ONLY ONE TO DEPICT AN INANIMATE OBJECT.

The ancient Greeks called this part of the sky Chelae Scorpionis, the scorpion's claws, but by the 5th century BCE, the Romans were describing it as a balance. Today, Libra is characterized as the scales of justice held aloft by neighboring Virgo. The names of its brightest stars reflect Libra's past: Zubenelgenubi is Arabic for southern claw, and Zubeneshamali, northern claw.

Lying just south of the celestial equator, the faint constellation of Libra is best found by locating its brighter neighbors. Libra's variable star Delta changes between the 5th and 6th magnitudes in a 2-day, 8-hour cycle, and Iota is a multiple star.



Zubeneshamali (β Librae)

A white main-sequence star and Libra's brightest. Some see a greenish tinge when viewing the star through binoculars or a telescope

KEY DATA

Size ranking 29

Brightest stars

Zubeneshamali (β) 2.6,
Zubenelgenubi (α) 2.8

Genitive Librae

Abbreviation Lib

Highest in sky at 10pm
May–June

Fully visible 60°N–90°S

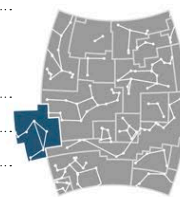


CHART 5

MAIN STARS

Zubenelgenubi Alpha (α) Librae
Double star

☼ 2.8 ↔ 75 light-years

Zubeneshamali Beta (β) Librae
White main-sequence star

☼ 2.6 ↔ 185 light-years

Gamma (γ) Librae
Orange giant

☼ 3.9 ↔ 163 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 5897

Globular cluster

NGC 5897

At magnitude 8.6, this globular cluster is visible only through a telescope. Discovered by William Herschel in 1785, it is 45,000 light-years away

Zubenelgenubi (α Librae)

A bright double star, consisting of a blue-white giant, magnitude 2.8, and a white main-sequence star of magnitude 5.2